with impressively deadpan sincerity.

In fact, Husain's career was marked by two major controversies that tie him to two significant turning points in modern India's political history. The first was his seeming endorsement of Indira Gandhi's Emergency, with a series of fawning artworks, most notoriously one depicting the then-PM as an avatar of Durga, in 1976. While this was received as a betrayal by the liberal intelligentsia and many of the artist's own comrades, 20 years later, he would become a sort of secularist canary in the majoritarian coalmine India seemed to be descending into. In a cruel irony, it was again Husain's blithe homage to goddesses, representations of Saraswati and Bharat Mata, painted years earlier, that invited the apparent outrage of militant Hindus. The ensuing attack on his home, threats to his safety, and legal harassment ultimately pushed him into so-called 'self-imposed' exile. He left India for the Gulf in 2006, accepted Qatari citizenship, and became a strange, painterly mirror for the fatwa-occluded figure of Salman Rushdie. He would never return to India, and died and was buried in London, in 2011.

THE UPCOMING, 100,000 SQ. METRES KNMA CENTRE—A GIGANTIC PUBLIC ARTS COMPLEX IN DELHI—WILL BE A PERMANENT HOME TO THE HUSAIN IMMERSIVE

The selection of paintings on display in Venice steers entirely clear of the controversies (not so the immersive, it must be said) and, tellingly, the only religious motif in evidence was the large acrylic on canvas, 'Karbala', anchoring the show at the top of the hall. The largest work on display, and making its public debut, this impressive piece from 1990 was also the most recent one here. Its resonances with the famous 'Guernica' are a reminder of the European painter whose distinctive style and global celebrity left their mark on Husain. The exhibition packs several surprises and delights into its catalogue, starting with a series of cutout wooden toys, made in the phase of youthful precarity when Husain took whatever work he could find in Bombay. A framed testimonial from his employer is an affecting reminder of his struggle, but the flat figures in these toys are also charged with the suppressed energy and adventurous melding of western and Indian motifs that he would later release onto canvas. Other revelations include the unusually abstract 'Untitled (Bundi landscape), 1962' that suggests a passing infatua-



LOOKING AT A MASTER M.F. Husain paintings at KNMA's exhibition in Venice